

Finance Committee of the Town of Westhampton
Town Hall
1 South Road
Westhampton, MA 01027

Minutes of Meeting, June 10, 2014

Meeting convened at 7:00pm

Members Present: Ellice Gonzalez, Jacqueline Brodeur, Joseph Pipczynski, Celeste Whiting, Aniko Giordano, Maryanne Duggan, Margaret Parsons, Thomas Cleary

Others: John Shaw, Art Pichette, Philip Dowling, Cheryl Provost

1.

New member Thomas Cleary introduced. Newly elected member and reelected members sworn in.

Ellice Gonzalez continues as chair and Mary Cleary as secretary, both unanimously reelected (8-0-0)

2.

May 20, 2014 minutes read and accepted (8-0-0)

3.

Members and selectmen who were present discussed how to streamline the budgeting process in the future. Most felt that there was a need to change the current approach and avoid the annual struggle to balance competing needs to arrive at a balanced budget.

The following points were raised:

- not enough information is provided to FinCom
- not enough consistency in the information provided
- not enough detail in the various departmental budgets
- submission of department budgets not timely enough
- some information difficult to get, due to one or few people having it

A number of suggestions were offered:

- foster cooperation and information sharing among departments
- educate public on capital needs and keep working to establish a capital fund to prevent volatility in tax rate
- educate the public that it's in everyone's interest to make full use of existing capital equipment

- communicate to various departments the revenue forecast and the upcoming economic climate faced by the town so they will know what the town can afford
- have a meeting among the larger departments at the beginning of the budget process to lessen competition for tax dollars

Mr. Pichette agreed that the town needs a better budgetary process. Mr. Dowling raised the point that most budget items are fixed and there is a limited amount that can be done about those expenditures. Ms Gonzalez said FinCom should strive to adopt "best practices" Ms Giordano noted that a list of "best practices" could be found in the 2012 Finance Committees' Handbook

4.

The selectmen present were alerted to problems that were uncovered in the past year in the maintenance of town accounts. Incorrect entries, missing entries, lack of timeliness in bookkeeping, all pointed to potential problems in closing the books on time, certifying free cash in September and setting the tax rate in November.

Selectmen present agreed that they would meet with the town accountant and a representative of the Council of Governments which provides accounting services to the town to resolve the problems identified.

Ms. Gonzalez asked that the FinCom be kept in the loop.

Meeting adjourned at 9:00 pm

Respectfully Submitted by Aniko Giordano